

Say-Mean-Matter (Modeled Example)

Purpose: Help students move from *what the text says* → *what it means* → *why it matters*.

Text for Students to Annotate

Many schools are debating whether students should be allowed to use cell phones during the school day. Some argue that phones are distracting and lower academic performance. Others believe phones can be useful tools for learning and communication, especially in emergencies.

Teacher Directions (Quick & Low-Stakes)

1. Read the text aloud once.
2. Students reread silently and underline **one sentence** they think is important.
3. Model the chart below **out loud** using the first sentence.
4. Students complete the chart independently or with a partner.

Reminder to students: This is thinking on paper—not a final answer. Write what you *think*, not what you think the teacher wants.

Modeled Example (Teacher Think-Aloud)

SAY (What does the text literally say?)	MEAN (What does it mean in your own words?)	MATTER (Why is this important?)
Some argue that phones are distracting and lower academic performance.	People think phones make it harder for students to focus and learn in school.	This matters because if phones hurt learning, schools might ban them to help students succeed.

Student Practice

Complete the chart using a **different sentence** from the text.

SAY	MEAN	MATTER

Sentence Starters (Optional Support)

- **Say:** The text states that... / According to the text...
 - **Mean:** This means that... / In other words...
 - **Matter:** This matters because... / This is important since...
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Exit Slip (1–2 Minutes)

Answer one: - Which part was hardest: Say, Mean, or Matter? Why? - How did writing it out help you understand the text better?

Teacher Note: This routine works well on half-sheets or in notebooks. Grade for completion to reduce writing resistance.